

it for them when matters go to extremes.

LOOKING TOWARD MEXICO.

The railroads now building in Mexico will give St. Louis a better opportunity than any other city to increase its trade with the interior of that country. One of the most important lines is virtually an extension of the Missouri Pacific system, which already puts this city in direct communication with the Mexican bank of the Rio Grande. Traffic by rail between the United States and Mexico will naturally have its starting point or terminus here. Hitherto the trade of the United States has been chiefly in the hands of New York, New Orleans and San Francisco, which have connection with Mexico by water. In 1881, for instance, out of \$8,317,802 worth of imports from Mexico, \$4,704,443 worth were received at New York, and \$1,046,009 worth at New Orleans, while of domestic exports amounting to \$9,138,077, \$3,031,851 worth went from New York, \$2,300,796 worth from San Francisco, and \$1,135,634 worth from New Orleans. These ports are not likely to suffer from the construction of railroads, though St. Louis and other places having land communication only will gain. The roads will stimulate trade, and the commercial and manufacturing centers from which they extend will reap the profit.

Our wholesale houses should not wait for a reciprocity treaty to give them a foothold in the "sister republic." There is no probability that a treaty will be concluded this winter, and none that the provisions of the agreement which Gen. Grant has charge of, if the outlines have been correctly reported, would extend American markets materially. Whatever markets St. Louis or Kansas City or Chicago acquire in Mexico must be fought for, not only as against our seaports, but also against England, France and Germany, and the best fighter will get them.

The returns of exports from this country to our neighbor last year show what is in demand. The most important item is manufactures of iron and steel—goods which this city is peculiarly well situated to furnish. Machinery heads the list. The new railroads will enable heavy forgings and castings to be carried without transshipment from the ironworks here as nearly as possible to the points where they are to be used. No manufacturers of iron goods generally have a better opportunity to get this trade than those of St. Louis. The exports from the country under this head last year amounted to \$3,861,514 out of a total of \$13,333,500.

Next in importance are cotton and cotton goods. In offering the latter New England has an advantage. At the same time, here is a good opportunity for the new cotton factories of the South to show their enterprise. They enjoy the natural protection of the saving of freight, both on the cotton and the fabrics. We export now to Mexico a considerable quantity annually of raw cotton. It ought to be manufactured by our mills. There is an opportunity for additional exports of corn, of agricultural implements and carts, of glass, of boots, shoes and harnesses, of provisions, especially lard, of sewing machines, and of lumber and manufactures thereof. Shrewd business houses will establish Mexican connections at once. This is no time for delay.